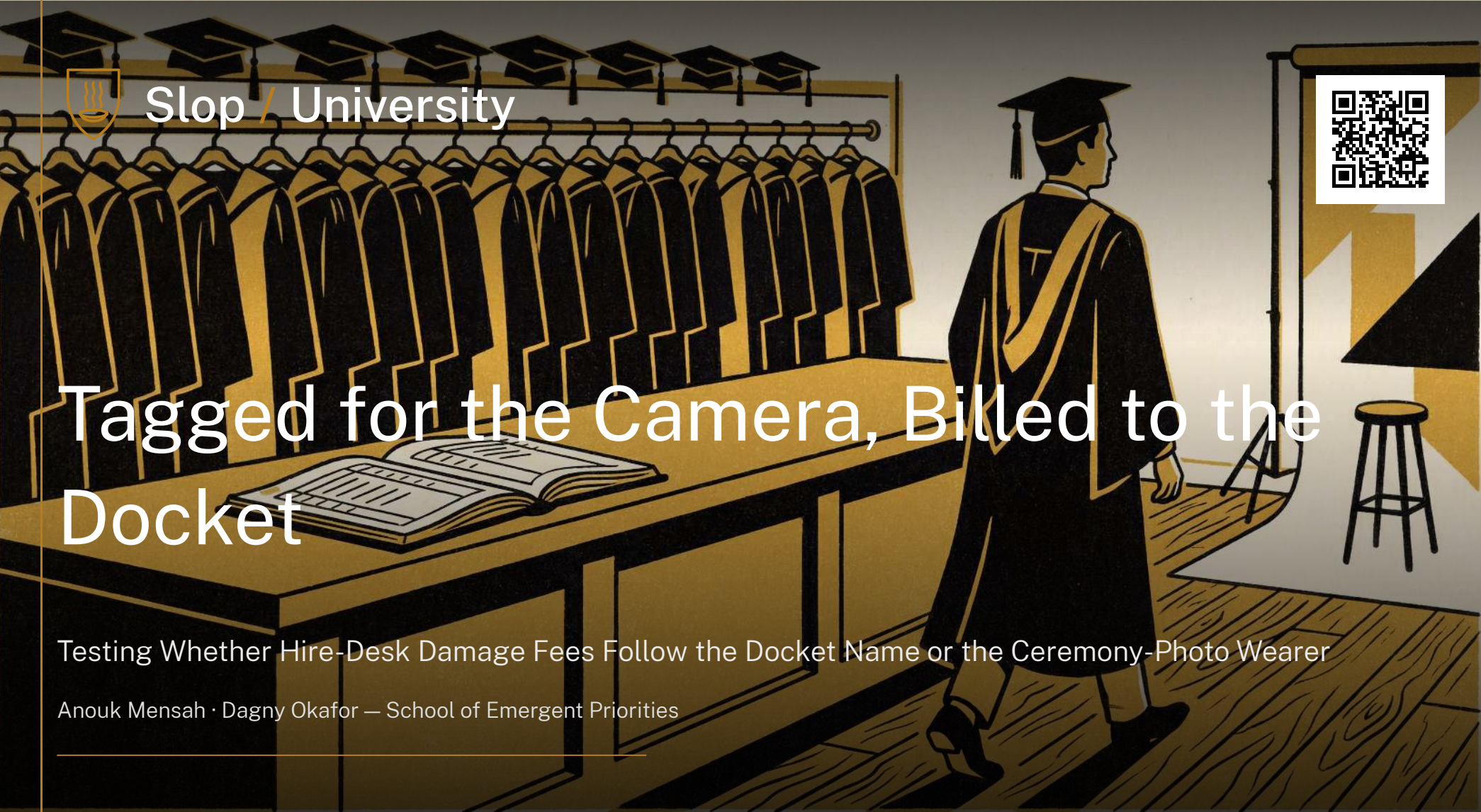




Tagged for the Camera, Billed to the Docket

Testing Whether Hire-Desk Damage Fees Follow the Docket Name or the Ceremony-Photo Wearer

Anouk Mensah · Dagny Okafor — School of Emergent Priorities

Background

Hired graduation gowns pass between friends in the run-up to the ceremony photo. A damage fee, when one is issued, is billed to whoever's name sits on the hire docket. Does the fee track custody, or paperwork?

Aims

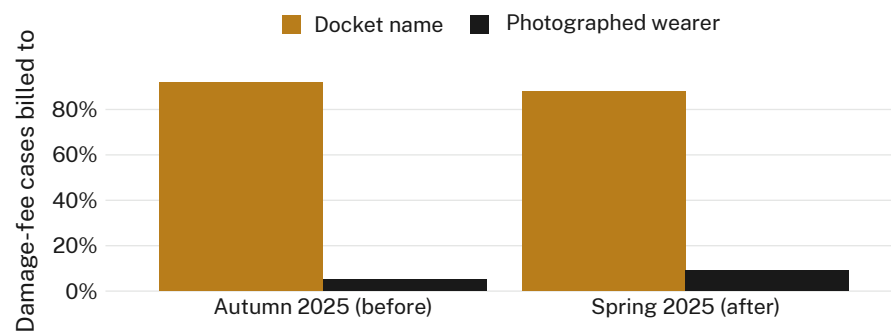
- Establish how often a gown's ceremony-photo wearer differs from its hire docket's named borrower
- Test whether damage-fee attribution tracks the docket name or the photographed wearer
- Test whether an accurate tag-photo mismatch report, handed to the desk before billing, changes that attribution

Study design

- n = 214 hired gowns · numbered fibre tags stitched into the collar lining at hand-out, imperceptible in wear · Autumn and Spring 2025 conferrals
- official ceremony proof-sheet photographs cross-referenced against each gown's tag number and its docket's named borrower
- before batch (n = 118) billed as usual; after batch (n = 96) gave desk staff the matched tag-photo mismatch report ahead of billing; thresholds for a billing "shift" pre-registered, not adjusted post hoc

Results

Tag-photo matching found the docket's named borrower was not the ceremony-photo wearer for 39% of tracked gowns. Damage fees nonetheless followed the docket name in the large majority of both batches, with accurate wearer information sitting on the desk at billing time.



Given the mismatch report at billing time, fee attribution moved from the docket name toward the photographed wearer by 4 percentage points between the Autumn 2025 and Spring 2025 conferrals — inside the trial's pre-registered no-adjustment band.

Discussion & conclusions

Findings are consistent with damage-fee attribution functioning as a paperwork artefact, not an evidentiary one. Accurate wearer identification barely moved billing practice inside the trial window, despite sitting on the counter throughout, and the desk's stated rationale for a contested fee did not change between batches either. Next: extend the after batch across a full academic year to test whether the small shift compounds, reverts, or is simply the report going unread.

Selected references

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Tag numbers destroyed at trial close; no photograph is retained without the docket-holder's consent. Ethics approval 2025/141.

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